

Plurilingual comprehension

The main notion represented by this scale is capacity to use knowledge of and proficiency (even partial) in one or more languages as leverage for approaching texts in other languages, in order to achieve a communication goal. Key concepts operationalised in the scale include the following:

- ▶ openness and flexibility to work with different elements from different languages;
- ▶ exploiting cues;
- ▶ exploiting similarities, recognising “false friends” (from B1 up);
- ▶ exploiting parallel sources in different languages (from B1 up);
- ▶ collating information from all available sources (in different languages).

Progression up the scale is characterised as follows: going up the scale, the focus moves from the lexical level to the use of co-text and contextual or genre-related clues. A more analytical ability is present at the B levels, exploiting similarities, recognising “false friends” and exploiting parallel sources in different languages. There are no descriptors for the C levels, perhaps because the sources used focused on the A and B levels.

Note: What is calibrated in this scale is the practical functional ability to exploit plurilingualism for comprehension. In any particular context, when specific languages are concerned, users may wish to complete the descriptor by specifying those languages, replacing the expressions underlined and in italics in the descriptor.

For example, the B1 descriptor:

Can deduce the message of a text by exploiting what they have understood from texts on the same theme in different languages (e.g. news in brief, museum brochures, online reviews)

might be presented as:

Can deduce the message of a text in German by exploiting what they have understood from texts on the same theme in French and English (e.g. news in brief, museum brochures, online reviews).

	Plurilingual comprehension
C2	No descriptors available, see B2
C1	No descriptors available, see B2
B2	Can use their knowledge of contrasting genre conventions and textual patterns in <u>languages in their plurilingual repertoire</u> in order to support comprehension.
B1	Can use what they have understood in <u>one language</u> to understand the topic and main message of a text in <u>another language</u> (e.g. when reading short newspaper articles in different languages on the same theme). Can use parallel translations of texts (e.g. magazine articles, stories, passages from novels) to develop comprehension in <u>different languages</u>. Can deduce the message of a text by exploiting what they have understood from texts on the same theme in <u>different languages</u> (e.g. news in brief, museum brochures, online reviews). Can extract information from documents in <u>different languages</u> in their field (e.g. to include in a presentation). Can recognise similarities and contrasts between the way concepts are expressed in <u>different languages</u>, in order to distinguish between identical uses of the same word/sign and “false friends”. Can use their knowledge of contrasting grammatical structures and functional expressions of <u>languages in their plurilingual repertoire</u> in order to support comprehension.

	Plurilingual comprehension
A2	Can understand short, clearly articulated announcements by piecing together what they understand from the available versions in <i>different languages</i>. Can understand short, clearly expressed messages and instructions by piecing together what they understand from the versions in <i>different languages</i>. Can use simple warnings, instructions and product information given in parallel in <i>different languages</i> to find relevant information.
A1	Can recognise internationalisms and words/signs common to <i>different languages</i> (e.g. haus/hus/house) to: - deduce the meaning of simple signs and notices; - identify the probable message of a short, simple text; - follow in outline short, simple social exchanges conducted very slowly and clearly in their presence; - deduce what people are trying to say directly to them, provided the articulation is very slow and clear, with repetition if necessary.
Pre-A1	No descriptors available

Building on plurilingual repertoire

In this scale we find aspects that characterise both the previous scales. As the social agent is building on their pluricultural repertoire, they are also engaged in exploiting all available linguistic resources in order to communicate effectively in a multilingual context and/or in a classic mediation situation in which the other people do not share a common language. Key concepts operationalised in the scale include the following:

- ▶ flexible adaptation to the situation;
- ▶ anticipation as to when and to what extent the use of several languages is useful and appropriate;
- ▶ adjusting language according to the linguistic skills of interlocutors;
- ▶ blending and alternating between languages where necessary;
- ▶ explaining and clarifying in different languages;
- ▶ encouraging people to use different languages by giving an example.

Progression up the scale is characterised as follows: at the A levels, the focus is on exploiting all possible resources in order to handle a simple everyday transaction. From the B levels, language begins to be manipulated creatively, with the user/learner alternating flexibly between languages at B2 in order to make others feel more comfortable, provide clarifications, communicate specialised information and in general increase the efficiency of communication. At the C levels this focus continues, with the addition of an ability to gloss and explain sophisticated abstract concepts in different languages. Overall there is also a progression from embedding single words/signs from other languages to explaining particularly apt expressions, and exploiting metaphors for effect.

Note: What is calibrated in this scale is the practical functional ability to exploit plurilingualism. In any particular context, when specific languages are concerned, users may wish to complete the descriptor by specifying those languages, replacing the expressions underlined and in italics in the descriptor.

For example, the B2 descriptor

Can make use of *different languages in their plurilingual repertoire* during collaborative interaction, in order to clarify the nature of a task, the main steps, the decisions to be taken and the outcomes expected might be presented as:

Can make use of English, Spanish and French during collaborative interaction, in order to clarify the nature of a task, the main steps, the decisions to be taken and the outcomes expected.

	Building on plurilingual repertoire
C2	Can interact in a multilingual context on abstract and specialised topics by alternating flexibly between <i>languages in their plurilingual repertoire</i> and if necessary explaining the different contributions made. Can explore similarities and differences between metaphors and other figures of speech in <i>the languages in their plurilingual repertoire</i>, either for rhetorical effect or for fun.
C1	Can alternate between languages flexibly to facilitate communication in a multilingual context, summarising and glossing in <i>different languages in their plurilingual repertoire</i> contributions to the discussion and texts referred to. Can participate effectively in a conversation in <i>two or more languages in their plurilingual repertoire</i>, adjusting to the changes of language and catering to the needs and linguistic skills of the interlocutors. Can use and explain specialised terminology from <i>another language in their plurilingual repertoire</i> more familiar to the interlocutor(s), in order to improve understanding in a discussion of abstract and specialised topics. Can respond spontaneously and flexibly in the appropriate language when someone else changes to <i>another language in their plurilingual repertoire</i>. Can support comprehension and discussion of a text spoken, signed or written in <i>one language</i> by explaining, summarising, clarifying and expanding it in <i>another language in their plurilingual repertoire</i>.
B2	**Can recognise the extent to which it is appropriate to make flexible use of <i>different languages in their plurilingual repertoire</i> in a specific situation, in order to increase the efficiency of communication. **Can alternate efficiently between <i>languages in their plurilingual repertoire</i> in order to facilitate comprehension with and between third parties who lack a common language. **Can introduce into an utterance an expression from <i>another language in their plurilingual repertoire</i> that is particularly apt for the situation/concept being discussed, explaining it for the interlocutor when necessary. Can alternate between <i>languages in their plurilingual repertoire</i> in order to communicate specialised information and issues on a subject in their field of interest to different interlocutors. Can make use of <i>different languages in their plurilingual repertoire</i> during collaborative interaction, in order to clarify the nature of a task, the main steps, the decisions to be taken and the outcomes expected. Can make use of <i>different languages in their plurilingual repertoire</i> to encourage other people to use the language in which they feel more comfortable.
B1	Can exploit creatively their limited repertoire in <i>different languages in their plurilingual repertoire</i> for everyday contexts, in order to cope with an unexpected situation.
A2	Can mobilise their limited repertoire in <i>different languages</i> in order to explain a problem or to ask for help or clarification. Can use simple words/signs and phrases from <i>different languages in their plurilingual repertoire</i> to conduct a simple, practical transaction or information exchange. Can use a simple word/sign from <i>another language in their plurilingual repertoire</i> to make themselves understood in a routine everyday situation, when they cannot think of an adequate expression in <i>the language being used</i>.
A1	Can use a very limited repertoire in <i>different languages</i> to conduct a very basic, concrete, everyday transaction with a collaborative interlocutor.
Pre-A1	No descriptors available

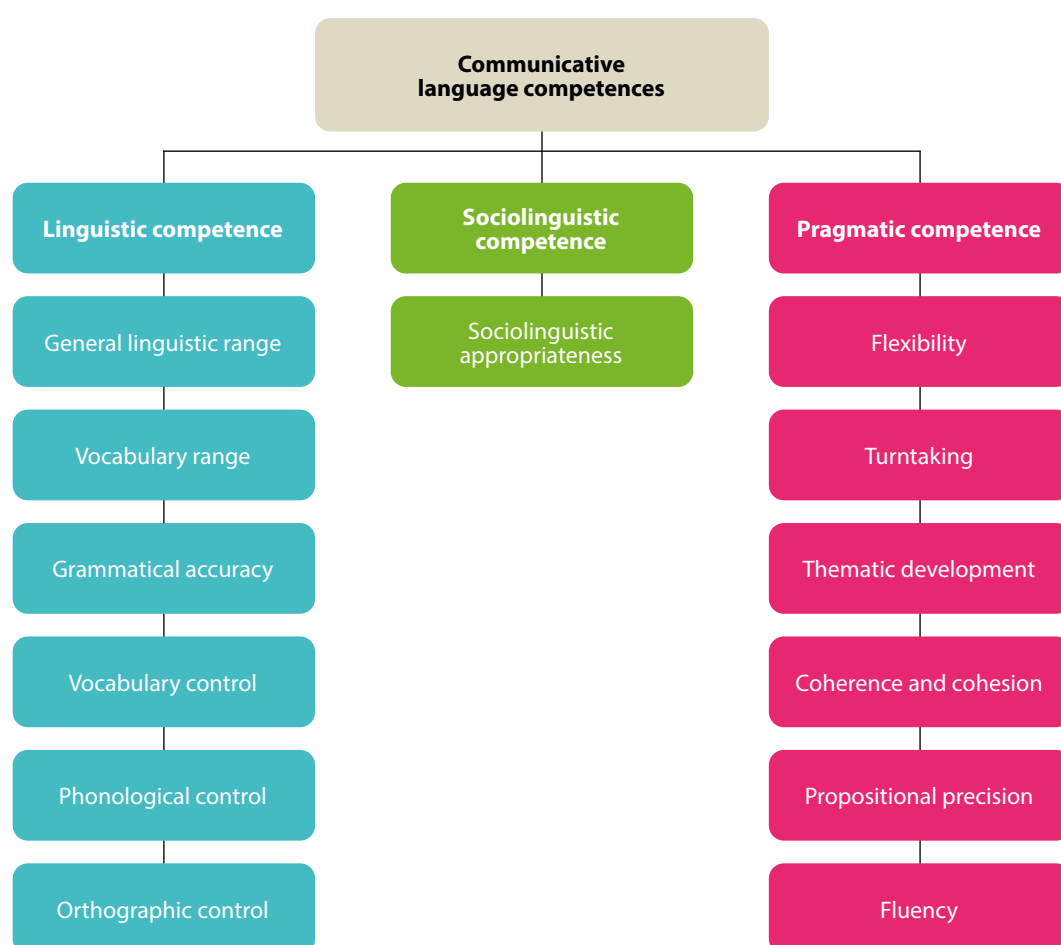
Descriptors marked with asterisks (**) represent a high level for B2. They may also be suitable for the C levels.

Chapter 5

THE CEFR ILLUSTRATIVE DESCRIPTOR SCALES: COMMUNICATIVE LANGUAGE COMPETENCES

As stated in the first chapter when discussing the CEFR descriptive scheme, the view of competence in the CEFR does not come solely from applied linguistics but also from applied psychology and sociopolitical approaches. However, the different competence models developed in applied linguistics from the early 1980s on did influence the CEFR. Although they organised them in different ways, in general these models shared four main aspects: strategic competence; linguistic competence; pragmatic competence (comprising both discourse and functional/actional competence) and sociocultural competence (including sociolinguistic competence). Since strategic competence is dealt with in relation to activities, the CEFR presents descriptor scales for aspects of communicative language competence in CEFR 2001 Section 5.2 under three headings: “Linguistic competence”, “Pragmatic competence” and “Sociolinguistic competence”. These aspects, or parameters of description, are always intertwined in any language use; they are not separate “components” and cannot be isolated from each other.

Figure 16 – Communicative language competences



5.1. LINGUISTIC COMPETENCE

Descriptors are available for different aspects of linguistic competence: “Range” (subdivided: “Morpho-syntactic range”, later renamed “General linguistic range”, and “Vocabulary range”); “Control” (subdivided: “Grammatical accuracy” and “Vocabulary control”), “Phonological control” and “Orthographic control”. The range/control distinction is a common one that reflects the need to take account of the complexity of the language used rather than just registering mistakes. “Phonological control” is presented as a grid with the categories “Overall phonological control”, “Sound articulation” and “Prosodic features” (stress and intonation).

The features of language used successfully at different levels are sometimes called “criterial features” but these are particular to different languages. Research in corpus linguistics is beginning to shed light on the nature of these features, and learners’ accuracy in using them, but results cannot easily be generalised across languages or across the linguistic backgrounds of the learners concerned.

General linguistic range

Since the primary evidence for second language acquisition (that is, progress) is the emergence of new forms and not their mastery, the “range” of language at the user/learner’s disposal is a primary concern. Secondly, attempting to use more complex language, taking risks and moving beyond one’s comfort zone are essential parts of the learning process. When learners are tackling more complex tasks, their control of their language naturally suffers, and this is a healthy process. Learners will tend to have less control over more difficult, more recently learnt morphology and syntax than when they stay within their linguistic comfort zone, and this needs to be taken into consideration when viewing (lack of) accuracy.

Key concepts operationalised in the scale include the following:

- ▶ range of settings – from A1 to B2, then unrestricted;
- ▶ type of language: from memorised phrases to a very wide range of language to formulate thoughts precisely, give emphasis, differentiate and eliminate ambiguity;
- ▶ limitations: from frequent breakdown/misunderstanding in non-routine situations to no signs of having to restrict what they want to say.

	General linguistic range
C2	Can exploit a comprehensive and reliable mastery of a very wide range of language to formulate thoughts precisely, give emphasis, differentiate and eliminate ambiguity. No signs of having to restrict what they want to say.
C1	Can use a broad range of complex grammatical structures appropriately and with considerable flexibility. Can select an appropriate formulation from a broad range of language to express themselves clearly, without having to restrict what they want to say.
B2	Can express themselves clearly without much sign of having to restrict what they want to say. Has a sufficient range of language to be able to give clear descriptions, express viewpoints and develop arguments without much conspicuous searching for words/signs, using some complex sentence forms to do so.
B1	Has a sufficient range of language to describe unpredictable situations, explain the main points in an idea or problem with reasonable precision and express thoughts on abstract or cultural topics such as music and film. Has enough language to get by, with sufficient vocabulary to express themselves with some hesitation and circumlocutions on topics such as family, hobbies and interests, work, travel and current events, but lexical limitations cause repetition and even difficulty with formulation at times.
A2	Has a repertoire of basic language which enables them to deal with everyday situations with predictable content, though they will generally have to compromise the message and search for words/signs. Can produce brief, everyday expressions in order to satisfy simple needs of a concrete type (e.g. personal details, daily routines, wants and needs, requests for information). Can use basic sentence patterns and communicate with memorised phrases, groups of a few words/signs and formulae about themselves and other people, what they do, places, possessions, etc. Has a limited repertoire of short, memorised phrases covering predictable survival situations; frequent breakdowns and misunderstandings occur in non-routine situations.

	General linguistic range
A1	Has a very basic range of simple expressions about personal details and needs of a concrete type. Can use some basic structures in one-clause sentences with some omission or reduction of elements.
Pre-A1	Can use isolated words/signs and basic expressions in order to give simple information about themselves.

Vocabulary range

This scale concerns the breadth and variety of expressions used. It is generally acquired through reading widely. Key concepts operationalised in the scale include the following:

- range of settings – from A1 to B2, then unrestricted;
- type of language: from a basic repertoire of words/signs and phrases to a very broad lexical repertoire including idiomatic expressions and colloquialisms.

Note: Vocabulary range is taken to apply to both reception and production. For sign languages, established and productive vocabulary is implied from A2+ to C2, with established vocabulary at A1 and A2.

	Vocabulary range
C2	Has a good command of a very broad lexical repertoire including idiomatic expressions and colloquialisms; shows awareness of connotative levels of meaning.
C1	Has a good command of a broad lexical repertoire allowing gaps to be readily overcome with circumlocutions; little obvious searching for expressions or avoidance strategies. Can select from several vocabulary options in almost all situations by exploiting synonyms of even words/signs less commonly encountered. Has a good command of common idiomatic expressions and colloquialisms; can play with words/signs fairly well. Can understand and use appropriately the range of technical vocabulary and idiomatic expressions common to their area of specialisation.
B2	Can understand and use the main technical terminology of their field, when discussing their area of specialisation with other specialists. Has a good range of vocabulary for matters connected to their field and most general topics. Can vary formulation to avoid frequent repetition, but lexical gaps can still cause hesitation and circumlocution. Can produce appropriate collocations of many words/signs in most contexts fairly systematically. Can understand and use much of the specialist vocabulary of their field but has problems with specialist terminology outside it.
B1	Has a good range of vocabulary related to familiar topics and everyday situations. Has sufficient vocabulary to express themselves with some circumlocutions on most topics pertinent to their everyday life such as family, hobbies and interests, work, travel and current events.
A2	Has sufficient vocabulary to conduct routine everyday transactions involving familiar situations and topics. Has sufficient vocabulary for the expression of basic communicative needs. Has sufficient vocabulary for coping with simple survival needs.
A1	Has a basic vocabulary repertoire of words/signs and phrases related to particular concrete situations.
Pre-A1	No descriptors available

Grammatical accuracy

This scale concerns both the user/learner's ability to recall "prefabricated" expressions correctly and the capacity to focus on grammatical forms while articulating thought. This is difficult because, when formulating thoughts or performing more demanding tasks, the user/learner has to devote the majority of their mental processing capacity to fulfilling the task. This is why accuracy tends to drop during complex tasks. In addition, research in English, French and German suggests that inaccuracy increases at around B1 as the learner is beginning to use language more independently and creatively. The fact that accuracy does not increase in a linear manner is reflected in the descriptors. Key concepts operationalised in the scale include the following:

- ▶ control of a specific repertoire (A1 to B1);
- ▶ prominence of mistakes (B1 to B2);
- ▶ degree of control (B2 to C2).

	Grammatical accuracy
C2	Maintains consistent grammatical control of complex language, even while attention is otherwise engaged (e.g. in forward planning, in monitoring others' reactions).
C1	Consistently maintains a high degree of grammatical accuracy; errors are rare and difficult to spot.
B2	Good grammatical control; occasional "slips" or non-systematic errors and minor flaws in sentence structure may still occur, but they are rare and can often be corrected in retrospect.
	Shows a relatively high degree of grammatical control. Does not make mistakes which lead to misunderstanding. Has a good command of simple language structures and some complex grammatical forms, although they tend to use complex structures rigidly with some inaccuracy.
B1	Communicates with reasonable accuracy in familiar contexts; generally good control, though with noticeable mother-tongue influence. Errors occur, but it is clear what they are trying to express.
	Uses reasonably accurately a repertoire of frequently used "routines" and patterns associated with more predictable situations.
A2	Uses some simple structures correctly, but still systematically makes basic mistakes; nevertheless, it is usually clear what they are trying to say.
A1	Shows only limited control of a few simple grammatical structures and sentence patterns in a learnt repertoire.
Pre-A1	Can employ very simple principles of word/sign order in short statements.

Vocabulary control

This scale concerns the user/learner's ability to choose an appropriate expression from their repertoire. As competence increases, such ability is driven increasingly by association in the form of collocations and lexical chunks, with one expression triggering another. Key concepts operationalised in the scale include the following:

- ▶ familiarity of topics (A1 to B1);
- ▶ degree of control (B2 to C2).

	Vocabulary control
C2	Consistently correct and appropriate use of vocabulary.
C1	Uses less common vocabulary idiomatically and appropriately. Occasional minor slips, but no significant vocabulary errors.
B2	Lexical accuracy is generally high, though some confusion and incorrect word/sign choice does occur without hindering communication.

	Vocabulary control
B1	Shows good control of elementary vocabulary but major errors still occur when expressing more complex thoughts or handling unfamiliar topics and situations. Uses a wide range of simple vocabulary appropriately when discussing familiar topics.
A2	Can control a narrow repertoire dealing with concrete, everyday needs.
A1	<i>No descriptors available</i>
Pre-A1	<i>No descriptors available</i>

Phonological control

The 2001 scale has been replaced in this publication. The description of phonology in CEFR 2001 Section 5.2.1.4 is clear, thorough and sufficiently broad to encompass more recent reflections on aspects of phonology in second/foreign language education. However, the 2001 scale did not capture this conceptual apparatus and the progression appeared unrealistic, particularly in moving from B1 (“Pronunciation is clearly intelligible even if a foreign accent is sometimes evident and occasional mispronunciations occur”) to B2 (“Has a clear, natural, pronunciation and intonation”). In fact, the phonology scale was the least successful of those calibrated in the original research behind the descriptors published in 2001.

In language teaching, the phonological control of an idealised native speaker has traditionally been seen as the target, with accent being seen as a marker of poor phonological control. The focus on accent and on accuracy instead of on intelligibility has been detrimental to the development of the teaching of pronunciation. Idealised models that ignore the retention of accent lack consideration for context, sociolinguistic aspects and learners’ needs. The 2001 scale seemed to reinforce such views and for this reason, the scale was redeveloped from scratch. A [process report](#)⁴⁵ on the sub-project is available on the CEFR website. From an extensive review of the literature and consultation with experts, the following core areas were identified to inform work on descriptor production:

- ▶ articulation, including pronunciation of sounds/phonemes;
- ▶ prosody, including intonation, rhythm and stress – both word stress and sentence stress – and speech rate/chunking;
- ▶ accentedness, accent and deviation from a “norm”;
- ▶ intelligibility, accessibility of meaning for interlocutors, covering also the interlocutors’ perceived difficulty in understanding (normally referred to as “comprehensibility”).

However, because of a certain overlapping between sub-categories the scale operationalises the above-mentioned concepts into three categories:

- ▶ overall phonological control (replacing the existing scale);
- ▶ sound articulation;
- ▶ prosodic features (intonation, stress and rhythm).

Intelligibility has been a key factor in discriminating between levels. The focus is on how much effort is required from the interlocutor to decode the speaker’s message. Descriptors from the two more detailed scales are summarised in more global statements, and explicit mention of accent has been used at all levels. Key concepts operationalised in the scale include the following:

- ▶ intelligibility: how much effort is required from the interlocutor to decode the speaker’s message;
- ▶ the extent of influence from other languages spoken;
- ▶ control of sounds;
- ▶ control of prosodic features.

The focus is on familiarity and confidence with the target language sounds (the range of sounds a speaker can articulate and with what degree of precision). The key concept operationalised in the scale is the degree of clarity and precision in the articulation of sounds.

The focus is on the ability to effectively use prosodic features to convey meaning in an increasingly precise manner. Key concepts operationalised in the scale include the following:

- ▶ control of stress, intonation and/or rhythm;
- ▶ ability to exploit and/or vary stress and intonation to highlight their particular message.

45. Piccardo E. (2016), “Phonological Scale Revision Process Report”, Education Policy Division, Council of Europe, available at <https://rm.coe.int/168073fff9>.

	Phonological control		
	Overall phonological control	Sound articulation	Prosodic features
C2	Can employ the full range of phonological features in the target language with a high level of control – including prosodic features such as word and sentence stress, rhythm and intonation – so that the finer points of their message are clear and precise. Intelligibility and effective conveyance and enhancement of meaning are not affected in any way by features of accent that may be retained from other language(s).	Can articulate virtually all the sounds of the target language with clarity and precision.	Can exploit prosodic features (e.g. stress, rhythm and intonation) appropriately and effectively in order to convey finer shades of meaning (e.g. to differentiate and emphasise).
C1	Can employ the full range of phonological features in the target language with sufficient control to ensure intelligibility throughout. Can articulate virtually all the sounds of the target language; some features of accent(s) retained from other language(s) may be noticeable, but they do not affect intelligibility.	Can articulate virtually all the sounds of the target language with a high degree of control. They can usually self-correct if they noticeably mispronounce a sound.	Can produce smooth, intelligible spoken discourse with only occasional lapses in control of stress, rhythm and/or intonation, which do not affect intelligibility or effectiveness. Can vary intonation and place stress correctly in order to express precisely what they mean to say.
B2	Can generally use appropriate intonation, place stress correctly and articulate individual sounds clearly; accent tends to be influenced by the other language(s) they speak, but has little or no effect on intelligibility.	Can articulate a high proportion of the sounds in the target language clearly in extended stretches of production; is intelligible throughout, despite a few systematic mispronunciations. Can generalise from their repertoire to predict the phonological features of most unfamiliar words (e.g. word stress) with reasonable accuracy (e.g. while reading).	Can employ prosodic features (e.g. stress, intonation, rhythm) to support the message they intend to convey, though with some influence from the other languages they speak.
B1	Pronunciation is generally intelligible; intonation and stress at both utterance and word levels do not prevent understanding of the message. Accent is usually influenced by the other language(s) they speak.	Is generally intelligible throughout, despite regular mispronunciation of individual sounds and words they are less familiar with.	Can convey their message in an intelligible way in spite of a strong influence on stress, intonation and/or rhythm from the other language(s) they speak.

	Phonological control		
	Overall phonological control	Sound articulation	Prosodic features
A2	Pronunciation is generally clear enough to be understood, but conversational partners will need to ask for repetition from time to time. A strong influence from the other language(s) they speak on stress, rhythm and intonation may affect intelligibility, requiring collaboration from interlocutors. Nevertheless, pronunciation of familiar words is clear.	Pronunciation is generally intelligible when communicating in simple everyday situations, provided the interlocutor makes an effort to understand specific sounds. Systematic mispronunciation of phonemes does not hinder intelligibility, provided the interlocutor makes an effort to recognise and adjust to the influence of the speaker's language background on pronunciation.	Can use the prosodic features of everyday words and phrases intelligibly, in spite of a strong influence on stress, intonation and/or rhythm from the other language(s) they speak. Prosodic features (e.g. word stress) are adequate for familiar everyday words and simple utterances.
A1	Pronunciation of a very limited repertoire of learnt words and phrases can be understood with some effort by interlocutors used to dealing with speakers of the language group. Can reproduce correctly a limited range of sounds as well as stress for simple, familiar words and phrases.	Can reproduce sounds in the target language if carefully guided. Can articulate a limited number of sounds, so that speech is only intelligible if the interlocutor provides support (e.g. by repeating correctly and by eliciting repetition of new sounds).	Can use the prosodic features of a limited repertoire of simple words and phrases intelligibly, in spite of a very strong influence on stress, rhythm and/or intonation from the other language(s) they speak; their interlocutor needs to be collaborative.

Orthographic control

This scale concerns the ability to copy, spell and use layout and punctuation. Key concepts operationalised in the scale include the following:

- ▶ copying words and sentences (at lower levels);
- ▶ spelling;
- ▶ intelligibility through a blend of spelling, punctuation and layout.

	Orthographic control
C2	Writing is orthographically free of error.
C1	Layout, paragraphing and punctuation are consistent and helpful. Spelling is accurate, apart from occasional slips of the pen.
B2	Can produce clearly intelligible, continuous writing which follows standard layout and paragraphing conventions. Spelling and punctuation are reasonably accurate but may show signs of mother-tongue influence.
B1	Can produce continuous writing which is generally intelligible throughout. Spelling, punctuation and layout are accurate enough to be followed most of the time.
A2	Can copy short sentences on everyday subjects, e.g. directions on how to get somewhere. Can write with reasonable phonetic accuracy (but not necessarily fully standard spelling) short words that are in their oral vocabulary.
A1	Can copy familiar words and short phrases, e.g. simple signs or instructions, names of everyday objects, names of shops, and set phrases used regularly. Can spell their address, nationality and other personal details. Can use basic punctuation (e.g. full stops, question marks).
Pre-A1	<i>No descriptors available</i>

5.2. SOCIOLINGUISTIC COMPETENCE

Sociolinguistic competence is concerned with the knowledge and skills required to deal with the social dimension of language use. Since language is a sociocultural phenomenon, much of what is contained in the CEFR, particularly in respect of the sociocultural, is also of relevance to sociolinguistic competence. The matters treated here are those specifically relating to language use that are not dealt with elsewhere: linguistic markers of social relations; politeness conventions; register differences; and dialect and accent.

Sociolinguistic appropriateness

One scale is offered for “Sociolinguistic appropriateness”. Key concepts operationalised in the scale include the following:

- ▶ using polite forms and showing awareness of politeness conventions;
- ▶ performing language functions in an appropriate way (at lower levels in a neutral register);
- ▶ socialising, following basic routines at lower levels, without requiring the interlocutor(s) to behave differently (from B2 up) and employing idiomatic expressions, allusive usage and humour (at C levels);
- ▶ recognising sociocultural cues, especially those pointing to differences, and acting accordingly;
- ▶ adopting an appropriate register (from B2 up).

	Sociolinguistic appropriateness
C2	Can mediate effectively and naturally between users of the target language and members of their own community, taking account of sociocultural and sociolinguistic differences. Has a good command of idiomatic expressions and colloquialisms with awareness of connotative levels of meaning. Appreciates virtually all the sociolinguistic and sociocultural implications of language used by proficient users of the target language and can react accordingly. Can effectively employ, both orally and in writing, a wide variety of sophisticated language to command, argue, persuade, dissuade, negotiate and counsel.
C1	Can recognise a wide range of idiomatic expressions and colloquialisms, appreciating register shifts; may, however, need to confirm occasional details, especially if the accent is unfamiliar. Can understand humour, irony and implicit cultural references and pick up nuances of meaning. Can follow films employing a considerable degree of slang and idiomatic usage. Can use language flexibly and effectively for social purposes, including emotional, allusive and joking usage. Can adjust their level of formality (register and style) to suit the social context: formal, informal or colloquial as appropriate, and maintain a consistent register. Can frame critical remarks or express strong disagreement diplomatically.
B2	Can with some effort keep up with and contribute to group discussions even when talk is fast and colloquial. Can recognise and interpret sociocultural/sociolinguistic cues and consciously modify their linguistic forms of expression in order to express themselves appropriately in the situation. Can express themselves confidently, clearly and politely in a formal or informal register, appropriate to the situation and person(s) concerned. Can adjust their expression to make some distinction between formal and informal registers but may not always do so appropriately. Can sustain relationships with users of the target language without unintentionally amusing or irritating them or requiring them to behave other than they would with another proficient user. Can express themselves appropriately in situations and avoid crass errors of formulation.
B1	Can perform and respond to a wide range of language functions, using their most common exponents in a neutral register. Is aware of the salient politeness conventions and acts appropriately. Is aware of, and looks out for signs of, the most significant differences between the customs, usages, attitudes, values and beliefs prevalent in the community concerned and those of their own community.
A2	Can perform and respond to basic language functions, e.g. information exchange and requests, and express opinions and attitudes in a simple way. Can socialise simply but effectively using the simplest common expressions and following basic routines. Can handle very short social exchanges, using everyday polite forms of greeting and address. Can make and respond to invitations, suggestions, apologies, etc.
A1	Can establish basic social contact by using the simplest everyday polite forms of: greetings and farewells; introductions; saying please, thank you, sorry, etc.
Pre-A1	<i>No descriptors available</i>

5.3. PRAGMATIC COMPETENCE

A simple way of understanding the linguistic/pragmatic distinction is to say that linguistic competence is concerned with language usage (as in “correct usage”) and hence with language resources and knowledge of the language as a system, whereas pragmatic competence is concerned with actual language use in the (co-) construction of text. Pragmatic competence is thus primarily concerned with the user/learner’s knowledge of the principles of language use according to which messages are:

- ▶ organised, structured and arranged (“discourse competence”);
- ▶ used to perform communicative functions (“functional competence”);
- ▶ sequenced according to interactional and transactional schemata (“design competence”).

Discourse competence concerns the ability to design texts, including generic aspects like “Thematic development”, “Coherence and cohesion” as well as, in an interaction, co-operative principles and “Turntaking”. Functional competence includes “Flexibility” in the use of one’s repertoire and the selection of appropriate sociolinguistic choices. All the scales for communicative language activities describe different types of functional language use. Knowledge of interactional and transactional schemata relates also to sociocultural competence and is to some extent treated under “Sociolinguistic appropriateness” on the one hand and “General linguistic range” and “Vocabulary range” on the other, in terms of range of settings and, at lower levels, repertoires for them. In addition, pragmatic competence involves “speaker meaning” in context as opposed to the “sentence/dictionary meaning” of words and expressions. Thus, articulating exactly what you want to say requires another aspect of pragmatic competence: “Propositional precision”.

Finally, saying anything requires “Fluency”. Fluency is generally understood in two complementary ways: firstly in a holistic way, representing the speaker/signer’s ability to articulate a (possibly complex) message. This more holistic usage is reflected in statements like “she’s an articulate speaker” or “his Russian is very fluent” and implies an ability to talk/sign at length, with appropriate things to say in a wide range of contexts. In a narrower, more technical interpretation, talking/signing at length implies a lack of distraction through breaks and long pauses in the flow. Putting “Fluency” under pragmatic competence cuts across the traditional competence/performance dichotomy used by linguists since Chomsky. As was mentioned in discussing the CEFR model, the CEFR does not continue that tradition. The view taken is that, in an action-oriented approach, competence exists only in action.

Flexibility

Flexibility is concerned with the ability to adapt language learnt to new situations and to formulate thoughts in different ways. Key concepts operationalised in the scale include the following:

- ▶ recombining learnt elements creatively (especially lower levels);
- ▶ adapting language to the situation and to changes of direction in conversation and discussion;
- ▶ reformulating points in different ways to emphasise points, express degrees of commitment and confidence, and avoid ambiguity.

	Flexibility
C2	Shows great flexibility in reformulating ideas in differing linguistic forms to give emphasis, differentiate according to the situation, interlocutor, etc. and to eliminate ambiguity.
C1	Can make a positive impact on an intended audience by effectively varying style of expression and sentence length, use of advanced vocabulary and word order. Can modify their expression to express degrees of commitment or hesitation, confidence or uncertainty.
B2	Can adjust what they say and the means of expressing it to the situation and the recipient and adopt a level of formality appropriate to the circumstances. Can adjust to the changes of direction, style and emphasis normally found in conversation. Can vary formulation of what they want to say. Can reformulate an idea to emphasise or explain a point.
B1	Can adapt their expression to deal with less routine, even difficult, situations. Can exploit a wide range of simple language flexibly to express much of what they want.
A2	Can adapt well-rehearsed, memorised, simple phrases to particular circumstances through limited lexical substitution. Can expand learnt phrases through simple recombinations of their elements.
A1	<i>No descriptors available</i>
Pre-A1	<i>No descriptors available</i>

Turntaking

Turntaking is concerned with the ability to take the discourse initiative. This ability can be viewed both as an interaction strategy (to take the floor) or as an integral aspect of discourse competence. For this reason this scale also appears in the section "Interaction strategies". Key concepts operationalised in the scale include the following:

- ▶ initiating, maintaining and ending conversation;
- ▶ intervening in an existing conversation or discussion, often using a prefabricated expression to do so, or to gain time to think.

Note: This scale is repeated under "Interaction strategies".

	Turntaking
C2	<i>No descriptors available; see C1</i>
C1	Can select a suitable phrase from a readily available range of discourse functions to preface their remarks appropriately in order to get the floor, or to gain time and keep the floor while thinking.
B2	Can intervene appropriately in discussion, exploiting appropriate language to do so. Can initiate, maintain and end discourse appropriately with effective turntaking. Can initiate discourse, take their turn when appropriate and end conversation when they need to, though they may not always do this elegantly. Can use stock phrases (e.g. "That's a difficult question to answer") to gain time and keep the turn while formulating what they want to express.
B1	Can intervene in a discussion on a familiar topic, using a suitable phrase to get the floor. Can initiate, maintain and close simple face-to-face conversation on topics that are familiar or of personal interest.
A2	Can use simple techniques to start, maintain or close a short conversation. Can initiate, maintain and close simple, face-to-face conversation. Can ask for attention.
A1	<i>No descriptors available</i>
Pre-A1	<i>No descriptors available</i>

Thematic development

This scale is concerned with the way in which ideas are logically presented in a text and related to each other in a clear rhetorical structure. It also involves following relevant discourse conventions. Key concepts operationalised in the scale include the following:

- ▶ telling a story/relating a narrative (lower levels);
- ▶ developing a text, expanding and supporting points appropriately, for instance with examples;
- ▶ developing an argument (especially B2 to C1).

	Thematic development
C2	Can use the conventions of the type of text concerned with sufficient flexibility to communicate complex ideas in an effective way, holding the target reader's attention with ease and fulfilling all communicative purposes.
C1	Can use the conventions of the type of text concerned to hold the target reader's attention and communicate complex ideas. Can give elaborate descriptions and narratives, integrating sub-themes, developing particular points and rounding off with an appropriate conclusion. Can write a suitable introduction and conclusion to a long, complex text. Can expand and support the main points at some length with subsidiary points, reasons and relevant examples.
B2	Can develop an argument systematically with appropriate highlighting of significant points, and relevant supporting detail. Can present and respond to complex lines of argument convincingly. Can follow the conventional structure of the communicative task concerned when communicating their ideas. Can develop a clear description or narrative, expanding and supporting their main points with relevant supporting detail and examples. Can develop a clear argument, expanding and supporting their points of view at some length with subsidiary points and relevant examples. Can evaluate the advantages and disadvantages of various options. Can clearly signal the difference between fact and opinion.
B1	Can clearly signal chronological sequence in narrative text. Can develop an argument well enough to be followed without difficulty most of the time. Shows awareness of the conventional structure of the text type concerned when communicating their ideas. Can reasonably fluently relate a straightforward narrative or description as a sequence of points.
A2	Can tell a story or describe something in a simple list of points. Can give an example of something in a very simple text using "like" or "for example". <i>No descriptors available</i>
A1	<i>No descriptors available</i>
Pre-A1	<i>No descriptors available</i>

Coherence and cohesion

Coherence and cohesion refer to the way in which the separate elements of a text are interwoven into a coherent whole by exploiting linguistic devices such as referencing, substitution, ellipsis and other forms of textual cohesion, plus logical and temporal connectors and other forms of discourse markers. Both cohesion and coherence operate at the level of the sentence/utterance and at the level of the complete text. Key concepts operationalised in the scale include the following:

- ▶ linking elements, mainly with logical and temporal connectors;
- ▶ using paragraphs to emphasise text structure;
- ▶ varying the types of cohesive devices used, with fewer "clunky" connectors (C levels).

	Coherence and cohesion
C2	Can create coherent and cohesive text making full and appropriate use of a variety of organisational patterns and a wide range of cohesive devices.
C1	Can produce clear, smoothly flowing, well-structured language, showing controlled use of organisational patterns, connectors and cohesive devices. Can produce well-organised, coherent text, using a variety of cohesive devices and organisational patterns.
B2	Can use a variety of linking expressions efficiently to mark clearly the relationships between ideas. Can use a limited number of cohesive devices to link their utterances into clear, coherent discourse, though there may be some “jumpiness” in a long contribution. Can produce text that is generally well-organised and coherent, using a range of linking expressions and cohesive devices. Can structure longer texts in clear, logical paragraphs.
B1	Can introduce a counter-argument in a simple discursive text (e.g. with “however”). Can link a series of shorter, discrete simple elements into a connected, linear sequence of points. Can form longer sentences and link them together using a limited number of cohesive devices, e.g. in a story. Can make simple, logical paragraph breaks in a longer text.
A2	Can use the most frequently occurring connectors to link simple sentences in order to tell a story or describe something as a simple list of points. Can link groups of words/signs with simple connectors (e.g. “and”, “but” and “because”).
A1	Can link words/signs or groups of words/signs with very basic linear connectors (e.g. “and” or “then”).
Pre-A1	No descriptors available

Propositional precision

This scale concerns the ability to pinpoint how to formulate what one wishes to express. It concerns the extent to which the user/learner can communicate detail and shades of meaning, and can avoid compromising their ideally intended message. Key concepts operationalised in the scale include the following:

- ▶ type of setting and information concerned (A1 to B1), with no restriction from B2, when the user/learner can communicate detail reliably, even in more demanding situations;
- ▶ degree of detail and precision in information given;
- ▶ ability to qualify, emphasise and disambiguate likelihood, commitment, belief, etc.

	Propositional precision
C2	Can convey finer shades of meaning precisely by using, with reasonable accuracy, a wide range of qualifying devices (e.g. adverbs expressing degree, clauses expressing limitations). Can give emphasis, differentiate and eliminate ambiguity.
C1	Can qualify opinions and statements precisely in relation to degrees of, for example, certainty/uncertainty, belief/doubt, likelihood, etc. Can make effective use of linguistic modality to signal the strength of a claim, an argument or a position.
B2	Can pass on detailed information reliably. Can communicate the essential points even in more demanding situations, though their language lacks expressive power and idiomaticity.

	Propositional precision
B1	Can explain the main points in an idea or problem with reasonable precision.
	Can convey simple, straightforward information of immediate relevance, getting across the point they feel is most important.
	Can express the main point they want to make comprehensibly.
A2	Can communicate what they want to say in a simple and direct exchange of limited information on familiar and routine matters, but in other situations they generally have to compromise the message.
A1	Can communicate basic information about personal details and needs of a concrete type in a simple way.
Pre-A1	Can communicate very basic information about personal details in a simple way.

Fluency

Fluency, as discussed above, has a broader, holistic meaning (= articulate speaker/signer) and a narrower, technical and more psycholinguistic meaning (= accessing one's repertoire). The broader interpretation would include "Propositional precision", "Flexibility", and at least to some extent "Thematic development" and "Coherence/cohesion". For this reason, the scale below focuses more on the narrower, more traditional view of fluency. Key concepts operationalised in the scale include the following:

- ▶ ability to construct utterances, despite hesitations and pauses (lower levels);
- ▶ ability to maintain a lengthy production or conversation;
- ▶ ease and spontaneity of expression.

	Fluency
C2	Can express themselves at length with a natural, effortless, unhesitating flow. Pauses only to reflect on precisely the right means to express their thoughts or to find an appropriate example or explanation.
C1	Can express themselves fluently and spontaneously, almost effortlessly. Only a conceptually difficult subject can hinder a natural, smooth flow of language.
B2	Can communicate spontaneously, often showing remarkable fluency and ease of expression in even longer complex stretches of language.
	Can produce stretches of language with a fairly even tempo; although they can be hesitant as they search for patterns and expressions, there are few noticeably long pauses. Can interact with a degree of fluency and spontaneity that makes regular interaction with users of the target language quite possible without imposing strain on either party.
B1	Can express themselves with relative ease. Despite some problems with formulation resulting in pauses and "cul-de-sacs", they are able to keep going effectively without help.
	Can keep going comprehensibly, even though pausing for grammatical and lexical planning and repair is very evident, especially in longer stretches of free production.
A2	Can make themselves understood in short contributions, even though pauses, false starts and reformulation are very evident.
	Can construct phrases on familiar topics with sufficient ease to handle short exchanges, despite very noticeable hesitation and false starts.
A1	Can manage very short, isolated, mainly pre-packaged utterances, with much pausing to search for expressions, to articulate less familiar words/signs, and to repair communication.
Pre-A1	Can manage very short, isolated, rehearsed utterances using gesture and signalled requests for help when necessary.

Chapter 6

THE CEFR ILLUSTRATIVE DESCRIPTOR SCALES: SIGNING COMPETENCES

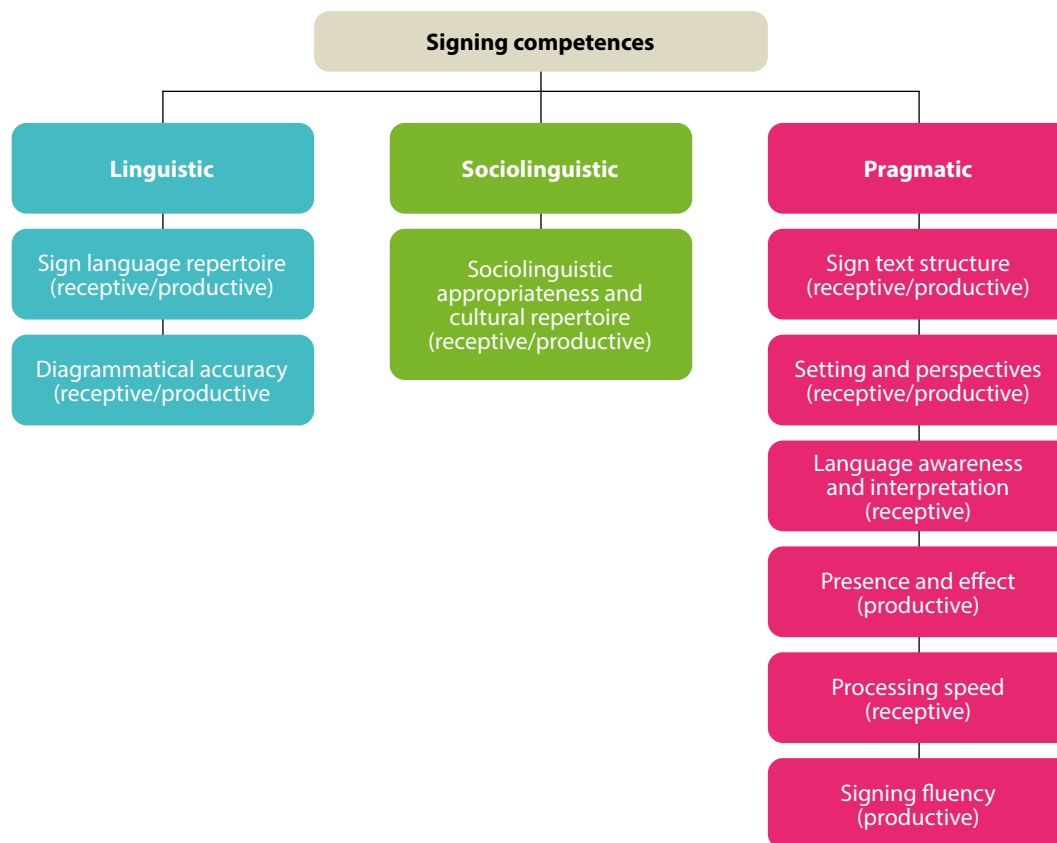
Many of the CEFR descriptors, especially those for communicative language activities, are as applicable to sign languages as they are to spoken languages, since sign languages are used to fulfil the same communicative functions. Hence these descriptors are modality-neutral, and modifications have been made to the formulation to emphasise this. However, there are obviously ways in which sign languages differ substantially from spoken languages. Fundamentally, they involve grammatical competences in the use of space, which we term “diagrammatical competence”. They also involve a broadened notion of the term “text”, namely for video-recorded signing that is not based on a written script. These competences go far beyond the paralinguistic features of communication through spoken language. The signing space is typically used to establish and later refer to relevant persons, places and objects in a form of spatial mapping. Sign languages then have syntax, semantics, morphology and phonology just like any other language. These differ of course from one sign language to another, as there are different sign languages in different countries, and sometimes more than one sign language in the same country. But there are certain common features such as the use of indexing, pronouns and classifier constructions. In addition, non-manual elements (facial expression, body orientation, head movement, etc.) and constructed action are used extensively in addition to hand and arm movements that are more traditionally considered to be the articulators of sign languages.

For communication, and reflecting contact with spoken language users, the repertoire of lexical and productive signs is supplemented by literally spelling out words or names using fingerspelling. Roughly, each letter of the spoken language script corresponds to a handshape. In due course, it may become lexicalised and phonologised. Fingerspelling, however, is a means of conveying something unfamiliar, for example a proper name, or a concept that does not have an established sign in the sign language used. Thus, fingerspelling is one of several contact phenomena that facilitate access to the written knowledge of spoken languages. Furthermore, fingerspelling is used to borrow new expressions from spoken languages, which may eventually also become lexicalised.

The categories for signing competences relate to the linguistic, pragmatic and sociolinguistic competences found in spoken languages, and therefore the descriptor scales specifically for signing competences are provided here under those three headings. Scales are provided for receptive and productive competences in seven pairs: two for linguistic competence, one for sociolinguistic competence and four for different aspects of pragmatic competence.

A few of the descriptors calibrated for signing competences are of a more global nature, similar to those included earlier. These have been kept in signing competences because they help to demonstrate the content coherence between the descriptors for signing competences and those for other areas.

Figure 17 – Signing competences



6.1. LINGUISTIC COMPETENCE

Descriptors are available for “Sign language repertoire” and for “Diagrammatical accuracy”. This distinction reflects the knowledge/control dichotomy and mirrors that between range and control/accuracy with respect to grammar and vocabulary.

Sign language repertoire

These two scales incorporate language resources that are accessed in both sign language comprehension and production, for example in the combination of non-manual features with classifier handshapes to indicate reference and possibly hand motion and orientation to express other aspects of the intended meaning.

Sign languages draw extensively on productive sign formation. As for spoken languages, the sign language lexicon consists of two sets of entries: established lexical items and productive elements used in the formation of (new) signs or forms respectively. Established signs have a fixed citation form, which is typically cited in dictionaries of sign languages. Elements of the productive lexicon combine in productive relationships between a narrow set of handshapes that operate in signing space to generate new, dynamic descriptions of events. The three-dimensional spatial nature of many expressions allows for variable, yet precise formulations. Learners progress in the use of these competences according to the multifaceted needs of expression by acquiring combinatory restrictions as well as principles for stylistic/aesthetic purposes.

Because of the high proportion of productive elements in sign languages, reception demands a high degree of processing of the simultaneously provided morpho-phonological and morpho-syntactic sub-structures, as well as bearing in mind the given contexts for spatial reference. In short, productive sign creation combines meaning-bearing elements that, in the respective combinations, cannot be found in the sign language lexicon, and comprehension demands a re-analysis of such signs. To meet particular communication needs – which encompass more than just a global understanding of what a message is about – learners have to reapply grammatical rules for productive signing, reapply combinatory restrictions, keep track of spatial assignments, and consider the applicability of principles for stylistic-aesthetic purposes. Such sign language comprehension

processes are reported by learners to be less facilitated by lexical resources than is the case in the comprehension processes of many spoken languages.

Key concepts operationalised in the two scales include:

- ▶ knowledge of basic forms, parts of speech, and meanings of manual signs, including registers and variants;
- ▶ basic linguistic knowledge of elements in sign languages for naming and referring, and for composing signs with reference to morpho-syntactic and morphological processes and simultaneous constructions;
- ▶ manual aspects such as lexical signs, idioms and chunks, as well as the morpho-phonological elements that are used in productive signs;
- ▶ knowledge of sign roots and of non-manual elements, for example the use of the eyes, the head, the body and body motion, speed of signing, amplitude of articulation, etc., as well as associated restrictions; these forms are accessed and used to interpret signing, naming and referring;
- ▶ knowledge of manual and non-manual elements of sign combinations (frozen forms, idioms and formulaic chunks) as well as knowledge of morpho-phonological rules which are used in productive sign creation; this also includes knowledge of, e.g. the subset of handshapes of a particular sign language;
- ▶ language-specific knowledge relating to the combination of the manual and non-manual elements into possible signs, since neither manual nor non-manual elements “surface” in isolation;
- ▶ conceptual knowledge of meaning and connotations, to the extent that for example a user/learner can interpret or produce metaphors or irony;
- ▶ and overall, demonstrate competence in understanding and using the manual and the non-manual elements of signs.

Sign language repertoire		
	Receptive	Productive
C2	Can understand abstract concepts, e.g. from the field of science, and assign them to the appropriate context. Can understand creative or newly coined descriptions of phenomena (e.g. a UFO). Can understand challenging texts on a range of topics and explain what they are about.	Can express themselves in abstract, poetic signing. Can formulate abstract expressions and concepts (e.g. in the academic/scientific domain). Can produce with one hand a productive or lexical sign (e.g. a depicting or lexical verb like "search for"), while simultaneously using the other hand as part of a constructed action (e.g. scratching their head in different places as if searching for something).⁴⁶ Can present a complex action or event in a linguistically aesthetic way, e.g. by employing handshapes as a means of playful expression.
C1	Can understand the meaning of mouthings in context. Can understand technical texts in their own field and make use of the information, ideas or opinions in them. Can understand specific, precise instructions, wishes, recommendations, etc.	Can express actions, objects and relations between these by using suitable classifier constructions (one- and two-handed) in varying ways with ease. Can employ the appropriate productive sign (e.g. a classifier) in order to highlight a particular meaning. Can sign comprehensibly using just one hand (the dominant hand). Can use a sentence to specify the precisely intended meaning of a vague term (e.g. specify "murder" through use of depiction). Can provide very broad coverage of a topic, taking account of the different aspects involved. Can switch between direct and indirect speech.
B2	Can understand and correctly attribute signed names for commonly known persons and institutions. Can differentiate nuances of meaning that are expressed with specific handshapes. Can understand idioms (and signs particular to the local community). Can understand what is meant when the signer paraphrases without producing the sign for the concept concerned. Can understand a large number of signs employed in everyday situations. Can deduce the meaning of individual unknown signs through the context of a sentence.	Can sign comprehensibly and precisely on a complex subject. Can adapt the signing style to the content and/or object being described. Can present a simple productive action through depiction and constructed action. Can use a differentiated choice of signs that corresponds to the type of text concerned. Can employ constructed action (actions are imitated one-to-one). Can always express their own opinion, even when the positions taken and opinions expressed by others are being presented. Can express the same content in a different language. Can alternate between productive and lexical signing. Can communicate information using the productive lexicon only. Can paraphrase lexical elements by using productive elements, e.g. by using depicting signs and other classifier constructions.

⁴⁶ This is also known as "body partitioning".

	Sign language repertoire	
	Can extract the relevant information from a short text provided it is presented in a simple and structured way. Can distinguish between signs that appear similar. Can deduce the nature of an object from non-manual cues and depictive signs. Can make indirect inferences about the features of the characters in a story from a signer's facial expressions.	Can fingerspell quickly and accurately. Can, in order to facilitate understanding, make a relevant comparison with other things or images or circumstances that the recipient already knows (e.g. "A porcupine looks like a big hedgehog"). Can employ different productive signs (e.g. handshapes indicating handling) when describing an action or event. Can employ mouthings in a differentiated manner that is appropriate to context. Can employ different means (e.g. non-manuals including facial expression, handshape, hand orientation, movement) in order to describe the size and shape of an object. Can present personal characteristics just with mouthings and constructed action.
B1	Can selectively extract information from a signed text, e.g., details of the time, individuals involved, places or appointments and indications as to how or why. Can understand productively expressed actions and processes. Can infer the chronological sequence of events from non-manual cues (close vs. remote events in terms of time). Can understand what kind of creature is meant when the signer imitates people or animals.	Can describe important characteristics of a person or object with the appropriate handshapes. Can modify productive signing appropriately to the context. Can make part of their contribution by using constructed action to present individual, simple actions. Can express the character and qualities of a person or protagonist by using constructed action. Can present actions or events through productive signing. Can vary the scale of their signing (larger, smaller) dependent on the situation. Can give a comprehensive description of a person, including facial expression, skin colour, make-up, hairstyle and profession. Can employ appropriate productive lexicon elements for reference, e.g. to animals, instead of lexical signs. Can use mouthings precisely to express specific contents.
A2+	Can understand content that a person expresses only by means of productive signs. Can understand the terms for common technical devices designed for deaf people's use. Can understand the meaning of modal verbs (e.g., <i>can</i> = <ability>, <i>must</i> = <command>, <i>want</i> = <wish>). Can extract specific information from everyday texts (e.g., numbers, names, places, persons). Can understand signing when the signer provides images to visualise the content.	Can use a range of signs. Can present different aspects of a plot or storyline (e.g. duration, as in "work through the night"). Can employ examples in order to illustrate something. Can indicate clearly the difference between two things. Can relay information in a short and minimal, yet intelligible way. Can, with preparation, use the right names and terminology related to the topic concerned. Can describe a person in terms of their characteristic features.

Sign language repertoire	
A2	Can identify details in an extensive description of a person/object, such as body shape, hairstyle, or occupation. Can understand non-manual information on the proximity or distance of a place or object. Can recognise and correctly interpret meaning expressed non-manually. Can recognise and understand the codified backchannelling signs of an interlocutor. Can understand simple reports of what the signer did. Can understand simple instructions, wishes, recommendations, etc.
A1	Can understand direct commands (e.g., "open the door"). Can understand quantities expressed non-manually. Can understand descriptions of clothes (pattern, colour). Can understand information on proportions, quantities, and size ratios. Can distinguish between signs that only differ according to the shape of the mouth. Can understand signs even if they are modified manually. Can understand the contribution to meaning from the shape of the mouth, e.g., puffed up or contracted cheeks. Can infer the shape of objects that are described from non-manual signals. Can understand simple negation with <no>, <not>, or a shake of the head. Can understand expressions via fingerspelling if they do not understand the lexical signs. Can recognise and understand facial feedback from the interlocutor (agreement/rejection).
	Can express their own opinion. Can present visually simple information like actions and relationships (e.g. in the family). Can sign a direct demand. Can express an amount/quantity through non-manual cues. Can express proximity and distance by using appropriate non-manual cues. Can describe the design, colour and texture of clothes.
	Can produce correct mouthings and employ them to differentiate between otherwise identical signs. Can spell names and technical expressions, among other things, using fingerspelling. Can describe physical shape (height, width, length). Can sign direct requests. Can sign conventional greetings and leave-taking expressions. Can describe a person through facial expressions, hair and physical characteristics or through things the person often wears. Can produce clear and unambiguous handshapes. Can produce the lexical signs for months, days of the week and times of the day. Can state their opinion (agree, disagree).

Diagrammatical accuracy

Diagrammatical accuracy describes the correctness, accuracy, precision and complexity of syntactic expressions. Taken together, these aspects determine the comprehensibility of the intended meanings of the signed expressions. The competences here relate to manual and non-manual elements; they encompass knowledge and observation of syntactic rules and principles, use of signing space, the bodily expression necessary, head motions and so on. Receptive competences include correctly analysing parts of speech, spatial relations of structured expressions, particular contributions of clausal and phrasal functions, non-manual markings (e.g. to indicate scope, spatial reference, topicalised phrases).

These competences relate to the expression of textuality (see “Sign text structure”) as they are used in structuring signed texts by applying a number of strategies that may include, for example, a specific arrangement of the signing space or rhetorical questions to introduce a new point. This scale also shares commonalities with the scale “Sign language repertoire” because it is fed by lexical knowledge of manual and non-manual meaning–form relationships. “Diagrammatical accuracy” thus also relies on non-manual elements, for example the raising of eyebrows to indicate particular grammatical constructions, and to mark a range of adverbials.

Key concepts operationalised in the receptive scale include:

- ▶ the exact memorisation of discourse referents and relations located in signing space;
- ▶ the interpretation of different references (e.g. of established elements in signing space, indexing, pronouns, classifiers, congruency, etc.);
- ▶ the interpretation of situated events in time as well as temporal relationships and reference to time and duration;
- ▶ interpretation of non-manual elements (e.g. use and scope of upper body, facial expression, eye gaze);
- ▶ comprehension of sign sequences and linked clauses;
- ▶ comprehension of inflected forms, e.g. verbs or other predicates.

Key concepts operationalised in the productive scale include:

- ▶ an appropriate use of the signing space, taking account of existing conventions;
- ▶ the expression of situated events in time or of temporal relationships by establishing appropriate time references;
- ▶ consistency in and accuracy of referencing (to established elements in signing space, indexing, pronouns, classifier constructions, etc.);
- ▶ accuracy of non-manual elements (e.g. the range of use of upper body, the use of the body in the articulation of constructed action, facial expression, head movements, etc.);
- ▶ accuracy of sign sequences necessary to express certain concepts (e.g. cause and effect);
- ▶ use of particular conjunctions or serialisations;
- ▶ use of certain structures, e.g. ability to modulate verbs;
- ▶ means for structuring sign texts appropriate for the respective text type.

Diagrammatical accuracy		
	Receptive	Productive
C2	No descriptors available; see B2+	No descriptors available; see B2+
C1	No descriptors available; see B2+	No descriptors available; see B2+
B2	Can distinguish the various temporal relationships between the actions and events (simultaneous events, previous event, subsequent event). Can distinguish between whether an action involves several people (objects) or many actions involve one person (subject). Can distinguish between direct and indirect speech in signed texts. Can understand statements that contain predicates that take no agent, e.g., "the water is flowing now". Can recognise rhetorical questions even if linguistically expressed in a very economical way, e.g., by raising the eyebrows. Can assign classifiers to the correct reference object (e.g., animals) through the context. Can understand aspectual modulations (e.g., staggering, fast, creeping or rolling movements).	Can situate the different contents/actions in the text sensibly in the signing space in order to structure the text. Can maintain full consistency in the reference using indexing, productive signs, in short texts.
	Can distinguish on the basis of grammatical signals between statements about real and imaginary events. Can keep apart the characters and their actions even in longer texts. Can recognise sentences as units and indicate how many sentences a short text contains. Can understand verbal aspect (e.g., completion, repetition, continuation, result of actions).	Can use the signing space in a conscious manner, e.g. using the right side for <for> and the left side for <against> reasons. Can use a large or a small signing space, dependent on the situation. Can link productive signing with indicators of time (timelines). Can employ appropriate timelines in order to indicate the point in time or the duration of an event (for temporal relations: simultaneously, beforehand/ afterwards, after another). Can express how one does something; <with X>; <without Y>. Can express different temporal relationships (for example, three relationships: simultaneously; before and after; one after another). Can employ upper body posture when indicating time reference, e.g. lean forward for future. Can exploit an appropriate timeline in order to place past, present and future events in the correct relationship to each other. Can exploit variation in the sign order of subject, verb, object in a sentence in order to highlight something (e.g. SVO, SOV, OSV).